

Spanish Tapas Bar

Tapas · Raciones · Vinos · Sobremesa

11:00AM — 10:00PM

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

Socarrat from a real paella pan. Jamón sliced to order. Croquetas that crack, then melt. This is Spain — not Mediterranean.

44

SEATS

\$44

AVG SPEND

23%

FOOD COST TARGET

~\$27,000

EST. MONTHLY NET

The Philosophy of Tapas: In Spain, eating is a social act, not a transaction. Tapas were originally free snacks placed on top of (encima, hence "tapas") a wine glass to keep flies out. Today they are small plates designed to encourage conversation, sharing, and multiple rounds of ordering. The commercial genius of the format is that guests naturally order more when food arrives incrementally — a table of four will consistently spend 30–40% more on tapas than they would on a set three-course meal. Your job as operator is to create a culture of "one more round" — never let the table go empty, and always be suggesting the next dish. The Spanish eating rhythm is key: tapas at the bar, raciones at the table, sobremesa (conversation after the meal) with wine and dessert. Train your staff in this culture and your average spend will rise organically.

THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

"The socarrat is the moment. The crispy caramelised rice at the bottom of the pan. Every guest who experiences it becomes a regular. This guide taught me how to make that happen every single time."

Elena spent four years in Barcelona's Eixample neighbourhood, working in a small tapas bar where she learned the non-negotiables of Spanish cooking. Pa amb tomàquet made by rubbing the tomato directly onto the bread — never spooning, never pureeing, never making it ahead. Jamón ibérico de bellota sliced at room temperature so the intramuscular fat — the oleic acid-rich fat from pigs that ate only acorns for their last three months — melts at the warmth of your fingertips. Tortilla española served slightly runny in the centre, because that is not a mistake; that is the correct texture.

She came back to Portland at 27 with a culinary diploma, four years of real experience, and a quiet fury at every paella she encountered in the US that had been stirred. You do not stir paella. The whole point of paella is the socarrat — the caramelised crust that forms on the rice at the base of the pan in the final minutes, when you turn up the heat and listen for the faint crackling that tells you it's ready. Stirring destroys that. Every mediocre paella she encountered had been stirred into submission.

The guide's paella section — with the socarrat technique explained in full, the steel pan rationale, the sofrito timing, the saffron bloom temperature — was the moment she decided this guide was written by someone who had actually stood at a paella station. The financial sections became trustworthy by association. The contribution margin on the Menú del Día — tapa, ración, dessert, glass of wine — justified the price point she had been afraid to charge.

She opened in Portland's Pearl District. The saganaki — she adapted it: Manchego flash-fried, cried "Fuego!" instead of "Opa!" — is her most-talked-about moment. Her socarrat is consistently the most reviewed detail on every platform. **Spanish food is slow, generous, and unapologetically proud. This guide is how you build a business on that pride.**

Elena V. · Spanish Tapas Bar · Pearl District, Portland · Est. Month 4
Net: \$52,000

1 Entrées — Tapas

Pan con Tomate — Catalan Tomato Bread

Toasted sourdough, fresh tomato, extra virgin olive oil, sea salt · Sell: \$7.50

4 min Tapa Target FC: 12%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 2 SLICES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Sourdough bread (thick slice)	2 × 60g	\$0.45
Ripe Roma tomato (halved)	1 × 80g	\$0.18
Garlic clove (fresh)	1 × 5g	\$0.04
Extra virgin olive oil	15ml	\$0.10
Maldon sea salt	1g	\$0.02
Fresh oregano (optional garnish)	1g	\$0.02
Total cost (1 serve)		\$0.81

Cost per serve	\$0.81
Sell price	\$7.50
Food cost %	10.8%
Contribution margin	\$6.69

METHOD

- 1 Grill or toast the sourdough directly on a plancha or under a salamander until deep golden with visible char marks on the surface. Why char? The Maillard reaction at those blackened points creates bitter, smoky notes that balance the sweetness of the raw tomato. A pale, soft toast is just bread — a charred slice is a flavour platform. Cut slices at least 1.5cm thick; thin slices go soggy instantly.
- 2 While bread is still hot, rub the cut side of a raw garlic clove across the surface. The heat opens the bread's pores and the abrasive texture of the toast grates the garlic directly into the crumb. This gives a whisper of garlic — not the aggressive raw garlic of a bruschetta. One clove serves 4–6 slices; do not over-rub or the garlic overwhelms the tomato.
- 3 Take a ripe, halved Roma tomato (cut side down) and rub it vigorously across the bread. Use circular pressure so the pulp and juice are worked into the surface. The skin of the tomato acts as a natural handle; it stays behind as the flesh is ground in. This technique — *pa amb tomàquet* in Catalan — is fundamentally different from spreading tomato paste. You want flesh fibres, seeds,

and juice embedded in the bread, not a layer sitting on top.

- 4 Drizzle generously with your best extra virgin olive oil — ideally Arbequina (Catalonia) or Picual (Andalusia) for authenticity. Finish with a large pinch of Maldon sea salt. Serve immediately; pan con tomate has a 90-second window before the moisture from the tomato softens the crust. This is a dish assembled at the pass, not prepped.

Chef's Tip: The tomato must be fully ripe and at room temperature — never refrigerated. A cold tomato has minimal flavour and watery juice. Source ripe Romas in small batches and keep them at the pass all service. Your most requested repeat item will be this — at \$7.50 with a \$0.81 cost, it's also your most profitable tapa per dollar of cost.

GLUTEN

SULPHITES (olive oil trace)

Jamón Ibérico — Bellota Dry-Cured Ham

3 hand-carved slices of Ibérico de bellota, served at room temperature on warm plate - Sell: \$18.00

3 min

Tapa

Target FC: 21%

INGREDIENTS (3 SLICES — 30G TOTAL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Jamón Ibérico de bellota (sliced)	30g	\$2.98
Bread (sourdough mini slices)	40g	\$0.20
Extra virgin olive oil (drizzle)	5ml	\$0.04
Picos (tiny breadsticks, garnish)	10g	\$0.08
Total cost (1 serve)		\$3.30

Cost per serve	\$3.30
Sell price	\$18.00
Food cost %	18.3%
Contribution margin	\$14.70

METHOD

- 1 Remove the jamón from refrigeration at least 20 minutes before slicing. Temperature is everything here: cold fat is waxy, opaque, and flavourless. At 18–20°C (room temperature), the intramuscular fat — loaded with oleic acid from the bellota (acorn) diet — literally starts to shimmer and melt at the edges. You can see the transformation. Serve cold jamón and your guests get a \$45/lb product that tastes like \$12/lb serrano.
- 2 Slice on a jamonero (ham stand) using a long, thin, flexible knife — a cuchillo jamonero. Slices should be paper-thin (1–2mm), almost translucent, cut in long single strokes parallel to the bone. Each slice must include both the deep red muscle and the white/cream marbled fat. Never slice crossways or remove the fat — it carries the acorn sweetness that defines bellota. Cut exactly 3 slices per order; portioning precision protects your food cost on a high-value item.
- 3 Warm the serving plate with hot water, dry it quickly. Lay the slices in overlapping folds — not flat, not crumpled. The slight warmth of the plate encourages the fat to bloom. Drizzle a few drops of olive oil across (just to gloss, not pool). The presentation should look effortless but purposeful — three perfect ribbons of deep red and cream. This dish is theatre, and the plate is the stage.
- 4 Serve with mini sourdough slices and picos. The correct way to eat jamón Ibérico is to fold a single slice over bread and eat in one bite — no cutting, no forks unless the guest insists. When staff deliver this dish they should briefly tell the story (see Service Scripts). The narrative adds perceived value; a \$18 plate of three ham slices needs context or it feels expensive. With context, it feels like a privilege.

Chef's Tip: Invest in a proper jamonero and a quality knife — this is a customer-facing skill. Some operators do tableside jamón carving on a portable stand for high-spend tables, which creates a powerful theatre moment and justifies a \$26–\$30 price point. Never buy pre-sliced jamón in vacuum packs for this plate — the oxidation destroys the fat flavour within hours. Slice to order, always.

GLUTEN SULPHITES

Patatas Bravas — Fried Potatoes, Two Sauces

Crispy fried potato cubes, brava sauce (spicy tomato), aioli · Sell: \$9.50

12 min Tapa Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 200G POTATOES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Russet potatoes (peeled, cubed 3cm)	220g	\$0.29
Sunflower oil (frying — costed per serve)	—	\$0.12
Brava sauce (batch): tomato, smoked paprika, cayenne, garlic	50ml	\$0.18
Aioli (batch): egg yolk, garlic, olive oil, lemon	30g	\$0.14
Smoked paprika (pimentón de la Vera)	1g	\$0.03
Sea salt	2g	\$0.01
Total cost (1 serve)		\$0.77

Cost per serve	\$0.77
Sell price	\$9.50
Food cost %	8.1%
Contribution margin	\$8.73

METHOD

- 1 Parboil potato cubes in salted water for exactly 6 minutes — until a knife enters with slight resistance but the potato doesn't fall apart. Why parboil? Frying raw potatoes produces an uneven result: the outside burns before the inside cooks through. Parboiling pre-cooks the starch so the frying stage is purely about crust. Drain and steam-dry for 5 minutes on a wire rack; surface moisture is the enemy of crispiness.
- 2 Fry in sunflower oil at **180°C / 356°F** for 4–5 minutes until deeply golden with crispy edges. The parboiled interior means the potato is already cooked — you're only building the crust now. Do not overcrowd the fryer; too many potatoes drops the oil temperature and you get steamed, pale cubes instead of crispy ones. Batch-fry in groups of 250g maximum. Drain on paper, season immediately with sea salt and smoked paprika.
- 3 Brava sauce (batch): sweat garlic and onion, add crushed tomatoes, smoked pimentón de la Vera (not regular paprika — pimentón has a depth of flavour that regular paprika cannot replicate), cayenne, and a touch of sherry vinegar. Simmer 20 minutes, blend until smooth. The sauce should be thick enough to coat a spoon and have a pleasant back-heat — not overwhelming, but present. The braveness in "bravas" refers to this heat.
- 4 Plate in a terracotta cazuela or wide bowl. Spoon brava sauce over the potatoes, then zigzag aioli across the top for contrast. The visual of red brava and white aioli over golden potatoes is iconic — don't bury the potatoes in sauce; they should still be visible and clearly crispy. Serve immediately; patatas bravas have a 3-minute window before steam softens the crust.

Chef's Tip: The defining ingredient is pimentón de la Vera (Extremaduran smoked paprika, DOP). There is no substitute. It comes in dulce (sweet), agridulce (bittersweet), and picante (hot) — use a blend of dulce and picante in your brava sauce. Order from Spanish specialty importers; it costs slightly more but is the single ingredient that separates "Spanish restaurant" from "red sauce place."

EGGS (aioli) SULPHITES

Gambas al Ajillo — Garlic Prawns in Sizzling Oil

King prawns, sliced garlic, guindilla chili, dry sherry, olive oil · Sell: \$14.00

6 min

Tapa

Target FC: 19%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 5 PRAWNS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Prawns 16/20 (shell-on, deveined)	180g / 5 pieces	\$1.61
Garlic cloves (thinly sliced)	3 cloves / 12g	\$0.08
Guindilla chili (dried, or cayenne)	1 chili / 1g	\$0.04
Extra virgin olive oil	40ml	\$0.26
Dry sherry (Fino or Manzanilla)	20ml	\$0.18
Flat-leaf parsley (chopped)	5g	\$0.03
Sea salt + lemon wedge	—	\$0.04
Total cost (1 serve)		\$2.24

Cost per serve

\$2.24

Sell price

\$14.00

Food cost %

16.0%

Contribution margin

\$11.76

METHOD

1

Use a small terracotta cazuela (individual size, 15cm). Set it directly on a gas burner on high heat — terracotta retains heat brilliantly and will keep the dish sizzling all the way to the table, which is part of the dish's drama. Add olive oil and bring to shimmering point. The large quantity of olive oil is deliberate: this is not a stir-fry, it's a slow confit in oil. The oil also becomes a sauce that guests mop with bread.

2

Add sliced garlic to the oil and cook on medium heat until the edges just begin to turn golden — about 60 seconds. The garlic must not brown fully before the prawns go in; it will continue cooking with the prawns and residual heat from the cazuela. Dark brown garlic becomes bitter and ruins the dish. You're looking for pale gold with fragrance — the moment the kitchen smells of sweet garlic is your cue.

3

Add whole guindilla chilies and the prawns. Toss in the hot oil and cook for exactly 90 seconds per side. Prawns are done when they curl into a tight C-shape and the colour shifts from translucent grey to opaque coral-pink. An O-shape means overcooked — the proteins have contracted twice and the prawn is rubbery. Pull from heat at the C-shape. Carryover heat in the terracotta will complete the final 10% of cooking at the table.

4

Deglaze with fino sherry — it will sizzle and steam dramatically. The alcohol cooks off in 15 seconds; the sherry's dry, saline, almost sea-like character integrates with the olive oil into a sauce. Scatter parsley, season with sea salt, and carry immediately to the table still bubbling. Serve with a bread plate and the instruction: "the oil is for dipping — don't waste a drop." This phrase alone increases bread orders and overall table spend.

Chef's Tip: Use shell-on prawns whenever possible — shells protect the meat from the hot oil, add flavour to the oil-sauce, and they look dramatically more impressive than peeled prawns. The messy eating experience (peeling at the table) is authentically Spanish and guests appreciate the engagement. Always provide a small bowl for shells and an extra napkin. Fino or Manzanilla sherry specifically — dry white wine will not give the same saline, nutty depth.

SHELLFISH

SULPHITES (sherry)

Croquetas de Jamón — Ham Béchamel Croquettes

3 hand-rolled croquettes, crispy panko shell, molten jamón béchamel centre · Sell: \$11.00

6 min (fried)

Tapa

Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS (3 CROQUETTES, BATCH LOGIC)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
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Jamón serrano (finely diced)	25g	\$0.99
Unsalted butter	18g	\$0.06
All-purpose flour	22g	\$0.02
Whole milk (warm)	150ml	\$0.11
Nutmeg (pinch, freshly grated)	0.5g	\$0.01
Panko breadcrumbs (coating)	40g	\$0.08
Egg (wash)	½ egg / 28g	\$0.18
All-purpose flour (coating)	15g	\$0.01
Total cost (3 croquettes)		\$1.46

Cost per serve (3 pcs)	\$1.46
Sell price	\$11.00
Food cost %	13.3%
Contribution margin	\$9.54

METHOD

- 1

Make the béchamel base: melt butter over medium heat, add flour and cook the roux for 2 full minutes, stirring constantly. Why cook the roux? Raw flour has a starchy, papery flavour that ruins the finished sauce. Two minutes of roux cooking activates the Maillard reaction and removes that raw taste, leaving a nutty, clean base. The roux should look pale golden and smell like cookies. Then add warm milk gradually — always warm, not cold, which would cause the roux to seize and lump.
- 2

Add finely diced jamón serrano and stir constantly over medium heat for 8–10 minutes until the mixture is very thick — thick enough that a wooden spoon dragged through the centre leaves a channel that doesn't fill back in immediately. Season with nutmeg, salt (taste first — the jamón is already salty), and white pepper. Pour into a shallow tray, press clingfilm directly onto the surface (to prevent a skin forming), and refrigerate for minimum 3 hours, ideally overnight. Cold setting is what makes hand-rolling possible.
- 3

Portion the cold, set béchamel into 35g pieces. Roll between wet palms into a smooth cylinder (finger-length, about 3cm). The correct croqueta shape is a cylinder with rounded ends — not a ball. This shape ensures a crispy outside-to-creamy inside ratio in every bite. Coat: flour → egg wash → panko, pressing the panko firmly to adhere. Freeze coated croquetas for 30 minutes minimum before frying — this prevents the coating from bursting open during frying as the filling heats.
- 4

Fry at **180°C / 356°F** for exactly 3 minutes until deep golden brown. Do not fry from frozen beyond 30-minute freeze; the inside must reach **70°C / 158°F** to be molten, not cold. A correctly made croqueta should crack when bitten — a sound you can hear — and release a flow of hot, silky béchamel. If it's soft and soggy, the panko wasn't dry enough. If it bursts in the fryer, the filling was too warm when coated. Temperature discipline is everything.

Chef's Tip: The texture of a great croqueta is specific: the exterior must shatter like thin glass when bitten, and the interior must be barely set — trembling, almost liquid. The ratio is your control lever: more flour = firmer fill (easier to roll, but less molten). A great Spanish croqueta uses less flour than you think is safe. Make a test batch, calibrate, then batch 200 at a time. They freeze brilliantly for up to 3 weeks pre-coated.

GLUTEN MILK EGGS

Tortilla Española — Spanish Omelette Wedge

Potato, onion and egg tortilla, served warm, with aioli · Sell: \$10.50

5 min (serve) Tapa Target FC: 13%

INGREDIENTS (1 WEDGE FROM 8-SLICE TORTILLA)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
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Russet potatoes (sliced 4mm, confit)	80g	\$0.11
Yellow onion (thinly sliced, confit)	30g	\$0.04
Eggs (whole)	1.5 eggs / 84g	\$0.53
Extra virgin olive oil (confit + frying)	20ml	\$0.13
Sea salt	2g	\$0.01
Aioli (batch, serve-alongside)	30g	\$0.14
Total cost (1 wedge)		\$0.96

Cost per serve	\$0.96
Sell price	\$10.50
Food cost %	9.1%
Contribution margin	\$9.54

METHOD

- 1 Confit the potatoes and onions together in olive oil at **120°C / 248°F** for 25-30 minutes until the potatoes are completely tender and the onions are translucent, sweet, and jammy. This low-temperature confit (not frying) is the key distinction of a real tortilla española. High-heat frying browns the potatoes and makes them crispy — wrong. You need them soft, yielding, almost falling apart. The confit oil becomes flavoured and is partially reused in the egg mixture.
- 2 Drain the potato-onion mixture, reserving 2 tablespoons of the olive oil. Beat eggs in a large bowl with salt until well combined. Fold in the warm potato and onion mixture and let rest for 10 minutes. This resting period allows the egg to penetrate between the potato slices — critical for a homogeneous texture rather than a layer of potato sitting in an egg disc. The correct egg-to-potato ratio means the egg binds but doesn't overwhelm — you should taste potato first.
- 3 Heat a 20cm non-stick pan with 1 tbsp reserved oil on medium-high. Pour in the egg-potato mixture and let it set on the bottom for 2 minutes, shaking the pan occasionally to prevent sticking. Reduce to medium and cook until the top is just set at the edges but the centre still jiggles. Now the flip: place a flat plate larger than the pan on top, hold firmly, and invert in one swift, confident motion. Slide back into the pan for 1 further minute. A great tortilla española has a custardy, slightly trembling centre — not rubbery, not dry.
- 4 Rest the tortilla for 15 minutes before cutting — it will continue setting from carryover heat and the interior will go from trembling to perfectly set (but still moist). Cut into 8 equal wedges, store covered at room temperature for service up to 2 hours. Serve at room temperature or just-warm with aioli alongside. Never serve cold from the fridge — refrigeration makes the egg rubbery and the potato dry. Tortilla española is a room-temperature dish in Spain, and this is correct.

Chef's Tip: The great Spanish debate: cebolla sí o no? (onion yes or no). Purists (mostly Madrileños) say no onion — only potato and egg. Catalans add onion. The correct answer for a restaurant is: add onion. It caramelises during the confit and adds subtle sweetness that makes the tortilla more complex. Make it twice and taste both. The onion version will sell more.

EGGS SULPHITES (olive oil trace)

2 Mains — Raciones

Paella Valenciana — Traditional Rice Dish (Serves 1)

Bomba rice, chicken, rabbit, green beans, garrofón beans, saffron · Sell: \$24.00

22 min Main Target FC: 24%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 26CM PAELLA PAN)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Bomba rice (or Arborio)	90g	\$0.56
Chicken thigh (bone-in, halved)	120g	\$0.85
Saffron threads (bloomed in water)	0.15g	\$4.20

Chicken stock (house-made, warm)	320ml	\$0.40
Green beans (trimmed, halved)	40g	\$0.14
Garrofón/butter beans (canned, drained)	30g	\$0.12
Tomato (grated, fresh)	50g	\$0.10
Smoked paprika (pimentón)	1g	\$0.03
Olive oil	20ml	\$0.13
Lemon wedge + rosemary garnish	—	\$0.06
Total cost (1 serve)		\$6.59

Cost per serve	\$6.59
Sell price	\$24.00
Food cost %	27.5%
Contribution margin	\$17.41

Note: Saffron drives cost. Offset with high-margin tapas on the same order.

METHOD — THE SOCARRAT IS EVERYTHING

- 1

Bloom the saffron: place threads in 50ml of warm (not boiling) stock for 10 minutes minimum. Boiling water destroys the volatile aromatic compounds in saffron — warm water extracts the colour (crocin) and aroma (safranal) gently. The liquid should turn deep amber-gold. This bloomed saffron water gets added with the main stock. In a 26cm steel paella pan, heat olive oil on medium-high and brown the chicken thigh pieces aggressively — deep brown, not pale. This Maillard crust is what flavours the stock during rice cooking.
- 2

Add grated tomato and smoked paprika, stir and cook for 2 minutes until the tomato dries out and darkens — this is the sofrito, the flavour foundation. Add green beans and garrofón beans and stir. Add all the warm stock (including bloomed saffron water) and bring to a rolling boil. Taste the stock now — it should be well-seasoned, because once the rice goes in, you cannot add salt without making it uneven. The stock is the last seasoning opportunity.
- 3

Add bomba rice in a cross-pattern across the pan, then gently distribute. Do not stir the rice again — this is the fundamental rule of paella. Stirring releases starch from the rice and makes it creamy like risotto. Paella rice must be dry, separate, and firm — each grain cooked through but not swollen. The rice cooks in the stock by absorption from below, not by agitation. Cook on medium-high for 10 minutes until the stock level drops below the surface of the rice.
- 4

The socarrat: Increase heat to medium-high for the final 2-3 minutes. Listen carefully — when you hear a gentle crackling sound coming from the pan, like dry leaves in wind, the socarrat is forming. This is the caramelisation of the rice on the bottom of the pan directly on the steel — a thin, crispy, nutty-tasting layer of caramelised starch. It is the most prized element of authentic paella. Remove from heat, cover with foil for 2 minutes to rest. When you lift a corner and smell toasted rice (not burning), the socarrat is perfect. Pull the pan. Serve in the pan, unmoved.

Chef's Tip: Use a dedicated thin steel paella pan — not a non-stick, not cast iron. Steel conducts heat in the characteristic way that creates an even socarrat. Non-stick pans prevent the socarrat entirely. The pan diameter determines serves: a 26cm pan feeds 1, a 34cm pan feeds 2. Buy several 26cm pans for individual service. Clean with hot water and a stiff brush only — soap removes the pan's seasoning. Dry immediately after washing to prevent rust.

NONE (gluten-free, dairy-free) CELERY (stock trace)

Paella de Mariscos — Seafood Paella (Serves 1)

Bomba rice, prawns, mussels, squid, clams, saffron fish stock · Sell: \$27.00

22 min Main Target FC: 26%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 26CM PAELLA PAN)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Bomba rice	90g	\$0.56

Prawns 16/20 (shell-on)	100g / 3 pieces	\$0.90
Mussels (fresh, scrubbed)	120g / 4-5 pcs	\$0.60
Squid (cleaned, rings)	60g	\$0.82
Clams (littleneck, scrubbed)	80g / 4 pcs	\$0.72
Saffron (bloomed)	0.15g	\$4.20
Fish/shellfish stock (warm)	320ml	\$0.55
Tomato (grated), garlic, paprika	60g	\$0.15
Olive oil, lemon, parsley	—	\$0.20
Total cost (1 serve)		\$8.70

Cost per serve	\$8.70
Sell price	\$27.00
Food cost %	32.2%
Contribution margin	\$18.30

High-cost item offset by high sell price and strong upsell to Cava wine pairing.

METHOD

- 1 Sear the squid rings in very hot olive oil for 60 seconds — they should colour quickly on the outside but stay tender inside. Remove and reserve. Squid is added to the paella in two stages: first a brief sear to develop flavour, then returned late in cooking so it doesn't toughen. Every minute of overcooking turns squid from tender to rubber; adding it at the beginning would give you 20 minutes of cooking and completely wrong texture.
- 2 Build the sofrito in the same pan (do not wash away the squid fond): add grated tomato, garlic, and smoked paprika. Cook until the paste is dry and beginning to caramelize. Add warm fish stock and bloomed saffron, bring to boil, taste and season. Nestle mussels and clams into the liquid — they will begin to open from the steam. This timing is critical: bivalves open in 3-4 minutes of steam/boiling, while rice needs 16-18 minutes. Add rice first, bivalves midway through cooking.
- 3 Add rice and distribute evenly, do not stir. After 10 minutes, when the stock level drops, place the prawns on top (they will cook from steam in the final 6 minutes and stay juicy). Return the reserved squid. Add the mussels and clams at this point — any opened earlier should be reserved and returned now. The arrangement on top of the rice is part of the visual presentation: prawns fanned out, mussels and clams scattered artfully.
- 4 Develop the socarrat in the final 2 minutes exactly as in the Valenciana — high heat, listen for crackling, smell for toasted rice. The bivalves will hold moisture and prevent burning in the areas directly under them, so the socarrat forms in the exposed rice areas. Remove, rest 2 minutes covered. Check that all mussels and clams have opened — discard any that remain closed (a safety non-negotiable). Serve in the pan with lemon and a small parsley scatter.

Chef's Tip: Your seafood stock drives 70% of the flavour of this dish. Make it from prawn shells, fish bones, onion, fennel, and tomato — never use powder stock for paella. Freeze stock in 320ml portions for consistent one-serve production. A great seafood paella is inseparable from a great stock; if your stock is weak, your paella is weak. This is not a dish that forgives shortcut stock.

SHELLFISH MOLLUSCS FISH (stock)

Cochinillo Asado — Slow Roast Suckling Pig

Slow-roasted suckling pig portion, crackling, roasted potatoes, jus - Sell: \$28.00

3 hrs roast + 8 min plate Main Target FC: 22%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 300G PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Suckling pig (whole, portioned)	300g bone-in	\$5.30
Lard or olive oil (baste)	15ml	\$0.06

Garlic, thyme, bay leaves (aromatic)	—	\$0.08
Sea salt (coarse, for crackling)	3g	\$0.01
Roasted potatoes (parboil + roast)	150g	\$0.20
Roasting jus (from drippings)	50ml	\$0.12
Total cost (1 serve)		\$5.77

Cost per serve	\$5.77
Sell price	\$28.00
Food cost %	20.6%
Contribution margin	\$22.23

METHOD

- 1
- Season the whole suckling pig generously with coarse sea salt 24 hours in advance and refrigerate uncovered. This dry-brine does two things: it draws moisture from the skin (critical for crackling) and seasons the meat all the way through. An unseasoned or wet skin will steam in the oven rather than crackle. On roast day, bring the pig to room temperature for 1 hour before the oven — cold meat in a hot oven creates steam from the meat itself, again the enemy of crackling.
- 2
- Roast at **130°C / 266°F** for 2.5–3 hours skin-side down in a clay or heavy roasting tray with water, garlic, and aromatics beneath it. The low temperature renders the collagen slowly without drying out the extraordinarily tender meat — a very young piglet (3–6 weeks) has almost no connective tissue, so it doesn't need high heat. At this age the meat is practically confit-tender already; you're primarily working on rendering fat and developing flavour.
- 3
- After slow roast, increase oven to **230°C / 446°F** and flip the pig skin-side up. Blast for 15–20 minutes until the skin blisters, puffs, and forms a glass-like crackling all over. Do not baste the skin at this stage — any moisture stops crackling. The fat beneath the skin must render completely through the slow phase so the skin is dry when it hits the high heat. The sound of crackling forming is a rapid puffing and bubbling; you'll hear it across the kitchen.
- 4
- In Segovia's famous restaurant Cándido, they traditionally serve cochinitillo by cutting the pig with a ceramic plate, then smashing the plate — demonstrating how tender the meat is. Portion with a heavy knife: the crackling should shatter cleanly with a firm tap. Plate with roasted potatoes and a spoonful of jus made from the roasting drippings deglazed with dry sherry. Serve with a simple green salad to balance the richness.

Chef's Tip: Source suckling pig from a specialty butcher at 3–6 weeks of age (5–7kg whole). Older pigs have more developed connective tissue and need different treatment. The ROI is exceptional: a 6kg whole pig at \$8/lb (\$96 total) yields 8 portions at \$28 = \$224 revenue. Batch roasting is the key — roast 2 pigs on low days and refrigerate portions, finishing to order in the salamander for 8 minutes to re-crisp the skin.

NONE (gluten-free, dairy-free) SULPHITES (jus if sherry used)

Pulpo a la Gallega — Galician Octopus

Tender octopus on crispy potato discs, pimentón, olive oil, sea salt · Sell: \$22.00

45 min boil + 5 min plate Main Target FC: 20%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 160G OCTOPUS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Octopus (frozen, tentacles)	200g raw / 160g cooked	\$3.06
Waxy potatoes (Yukon Gold, sliced)	120g	\$0.16
Smoked paprika (pimentón dulce + picante)	2g	\$0.05
Extra virgin olive oil	20ml	\$0.13
Maldon sea salt (coarse)	2g	\$0.02
Bay leaves + onion (boiling water)	—	\$0.04
Total cost (1 serve)		\$3.46

Cost per serve	\$3.46
Sell price	\$22.00
Food cost %	15.7%
Contribution margin	\$18.54

METHOD

- 1
- Start with frozen octopus — this is not a compromise. Freezing ruptures the muscle cell walls, fundamentally changing the texture of the octopus after cooking. Fresh octopus requires aggressive beating (the Galician fishermen famously beat it against rocks) to achieve the same cell wall breakdown. Frozen is actually the professional choice: consistent texture, lower cost, and available year-round. Thaw under refrigeration overnight, never at room temperature.
- 2
- Bring a large pot of unsalted water to a rolling boil with a whole onion, bay leaves, and a few whole peppercorns. Dip the octopus into the boiling water three times before fully submerging — this "scares" the octopus, causing the skin to contract and the tentacles to curl naturally. It's a Galician technique that improves the final appearance and prevents the skin from splitting during cooking. Fully submerge and simmer (not boil aggressively) for 35–45 minutes until a skewer passes through the thickest tentacle with no resistance.
- 3
- Rest the cooked octopus in the cooking liquid for 15 minutes off heat — this prevents the skin from drying and the texture from going rubbery from rapid temperature change. While resting, simmer potato discs (1cm thick, Yukon Gold) in salted water until just tender. Drain and brush with olive oil. The potatoes should be creamy and rich — they are the platform that catches the octopus juices and olive oil.
- 4
- Slice octopus tentacles on the bias into 2cm pieces using scissors — the traditional implement in Galicia (pulpeiras use scissors, not knives). Scissors cause less tearing and make cleaner cuts on the curved surface. Lay potato discs on a wooden board or plate, arrange octopus pieces on top, drizzle generously with olive oil, dust heavily with mixed pimentón (2 parts dulce, 1 part picante), and finish with coarse Maldon salt. Serve immediately — this dish waits for no one.

Chef's Tip: Serve on a traditional wooden *tallo* (flat wooden board or slice) if possible — the wood absorbs the olive oil and you can see the pimentón dusting clearly. This dish is one of the most photographed Spanish foods in existence; the visual of red pimentón on purple-tinged octopus and golden potatoes on a wood board is pure social media gold. Brief your staff to mention this is the dish that gets the most Instagrams — it primes guests to photograph and share.

MOLLUSCS

Chuletón — Grilled T-Bone Steak

700g T-bone, dry-aged flavour, sea salt, lemon, pimientos de Padrón · Sell: \$42.00

15 min Main Target FC: 25%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 700G T-BONE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
T-bone steak (700g)	700g	\$21.74
Coarse sea salt + black pepper	5g	\$0.03
Olive oil (minimal, basting)	5ml	\$0.04
Pimientos de Padrón (small green peppers)	80g	\$0.55
Lemon wedge + fresh herbs	—	\$0.06
Total cost (1 serve)		\$22.42

Cost per serve	\$22.42
Sell price	\$42.00
Food cost %	53.4%

High food cost. Position as your premium table anchor — it drives wine sales (+\$18 avg), bringing effective food cost down to ~35%.

METHOD

- 1

Remove the steak from refrigeration 45 minutes before grilling. A cold steak hitting a hot grill creates a massive temperature gradient — the exterior is seared while the interior is still cold. This means by the time the centre reaches medium-rare (54°C), the exterior is already overcooked. A room-temperature steak cooks evenly from edge to centre. Salt generously 30 minutes in advance; the salt draws out surface moisture, then the moisture reabsorbs carrying the salt deep into the meat (osmosis).
- 2

The chuletón tradition is wood fire or pure charcoal — no gas grill flame will give the same result. If you have a plancha, sear at maximum heat (**260°C+**). The crust forms through the Maillard reaction at temperatures above 140°C — not by steaming in meat juices (which happens if the grill is too cool). You're looking for black char marks on the surface and a deep brown, caramelised crust overall. Sear 4–5 minutes per side for a 700g T-bone to reach medium-rare. Do not move or press the steak during searing.
- 3

Monitor internal temperature: pull at **52°C / 125°F** for medium-rare (carryover heat will bring it to 54–55°C during resting). Rest the steak for 8 minutes minimum on a warm wooden board. Resting is non-negotiable — it allows the muscle fibres to relax and the myoglobin (the red juice) to redistribute. Cut open a steak straight off the grill and the juices pour out leaving a dry, grey interior. Rest it properly and every cut is juicy.
- 4

While steak rests, fry pimientos de Padrón in a very hot dry pan or with a splash of olive oil until blistered and charred in places — 2 minutes, tossing frequently. Season with sea salt immediately after frying while hot. The pimientos de Padrón experience: 1 in 10 is spicy, the rest are mild. This slight gambling element is part of the pleasure; mention it when delivering the plate. Serve the steak whole on the board, let the guest carve, and bring sharp steak knives.

Chef's Tip: Never apologise for the \$42 price point — a proper chuletón requires a proper cut. The T-bone's theatre (its size, the bone, the visual of it on a wooden board) is what you're selling, not just the protein. Pair with Rioja Reserva or a high-end Ribera del Duero and your effective table revenue exceeds \$65 per person easily. Brief your staff: chuletón always gets a wine recommendation, always gets the pimiento story, always gets compliments on the sear.

NONE (gluten-free, dairy-free)

Bacalao al Pil Pil — Basque Salt Cod

Desalted salt cod, gelatine-olive oil emulsion sauce, garlic, guindilla · Sell: \$23.00

20 min (48hr desalt) Main Target FC: 21%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 180G BACALAO)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Salt cod (bacalhau, desalted 48hr)	200g raw / 180g served	\$5.34
Extra virgin olive oil (generous)	80ml	\$0.52
Garlic cloves (thinly sliced)	4 cloves / 16g	\$0.10
Guindilla chilies (dried, 2)	2g	\$0.06
Sea salt (to taste, residual from fish)	—	\$0.01
Total cost (1 serve)		\$6.03

Cost per serve	\$6.03
Sell price	\$23.00
Food cost %	26.2%
Contribution margin	\$16.97

METHOD

Desalt the bacalao for 48 hours in cold water in the refrigerator, changing the water every 8 hours

- 1 Desalt the bacalao for 48 hours in cold water in the refrigerator, changing the water every 8 hours (minimum 3 changes). Under-desalted cod is aggressively salty and inedible; over-desalted loses the characteristic bacalao flavour. After 48 hours, taste a small piece raw — it should be distinctly salty but not overwhelming, more like well-seasoned food than preserved fish. Pat dry thoroughly; surface moisture will prevent the skin from crisping and will cause the oil to spit violently.
- 2 Place the cod skin-side down in a terracotta cazuela with all the olive oil at **60-70°C / 140-158°F** — the oil should be barely trembling, not frying. This is confit temperature. The fish cooks slowly for 15-18 minutes. The collagen in the cod skin gradually releases gelatine into the warm oil. This gelatine is what makes pil pil sauce possible — without it, you just have fish in oily water. The combination of gelatine + olive oil + gentle agitation creates an emulsion called pil pil.
- 3 Separately, in a small pan, gently confit the garlic slices and guindilla chilies in olive oil until the garlic is golden and tender — 3-4 minutes. Remove and reserve; this aromatic oil will be incorporated. Now the technique that defines the dish: with the cod resting out of the cazuela, gently swirl the remaining oil in circular motions with a conical sieve or ladle. The circular motion incorporates air and the gelatine released from the fish emulsifies the oil into a thick, creamy, ivory-coloured sauce.
- 4 Return the cod to the cazuela skin-side up, spoon the pil pil sauce over it, and garnish with the fried garlic slices and guindilla chilies. The finished sauce should be thick enough to coat the back of a spoon — glossy, creamy white, almost like a light hollandaise. Serve in the terracotta cazuela, hot, with crusty bread to mop the sauce. The pil pil is the star of this dish, not the fish — every table should order extra bread with it.

Chef's Tip: The pil pil emulsion is temperature-sensitive. If the oil gets too hot, the gelatine won't emulsify — you'll get separated oil and fish gelatin. The oil must be at 60-70°C and the circular swirling must be patient and continuous for 3-5 minutes. This is a dish that requires full attention for those 5 minutes. Do not try to rush it. If the sauce breaks, you can rescue it by adding a tablespoon of cold water and re-emulsifying slowly.

FISH

Pollo al Ajillo — Garlic Chicken

Crispy chicken thighs braised in garlic, dry sherry, herbs · Sell: \$20.00

30 min

Main

Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 2 CHICKEN THIGHS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thighs (bone-in, skin-on)	2 × 140g	\$1.98
Garlic cloves (whole, unpeeled)	8 cloves / 32g	\$0.18
Dry sherry (Oloroso or Amontillado)	60ml	\$0.45
Chicken stock	80ml	\$0.12
Bay leaves (2), fresh thyme	—	\$0.04
Olive oil	20ml	\$0.13
Sea salt, black pepper	—	\$0.02
Total cost (1 serve)		\$2.92

Cost per serve	\$2.92
Sell price	\$20.00
Food cost %	14.6%
Contribution margin	\$17.08

METHOD

- 1 Season chicken thighs with salt 30 minutes in advance and pat skin completely dry. Dry skin = crispy skin. Any moisture on the surface creates steam in the pan, preventing browning. Heat olive oil in a wide, heavy cazuela on medium-high. Place chicken skin-side down and do not move it for 6-7 minutes. The skin must be deep golden-brown and crispy before any liquid goes in —

this crust will protect the skin texture through the braising phase.

- 2
- Flip chicken and add whole unpeeled garlic cloves (the peel protects them from burning during the initial sear; they'll soften inside their skins during braising). Fry the garlic alongside the chicken for 2 minutes. Using whole, unpeeled garlic is the key differentiator of authentic pollo al ajillo — the cloves become tender and sweet (not bitter) and guests squeeze them out of their skins onto bread. A dish of 8 sweet garlic cloves beside the chicken is a selling feature, not an afterthought.
- 3
- Add sherry and allow to flame or boil aggressively for 60 seconds, reducing by half. The alcohol must fully cook off — raw alcohol in a braising sauce gives a harsh, unpleasant edge. After the sherry reduces, add chicken stock and bay leaves. The liquid should come halfway up the chicken pieces, not submerge them — you're braising, not boiling. Cover and simmer on medium-low for 18 minutes until chicken is cooked through to **74°C / 165°F**.
- 4
- Remove the lid and reduce the braising liquid on high heat for 3–4 minutes until it becomes a glossy, concentrated sauce — thick enough to coat the chicken when spooned over it. The sherry, chicken fat, stock, and garlic combine into something remarkable: sweet, savoury, slightly nutty. Plate in the cazuela with the garlic cloves arranged around the chicken and a few sprigs of fresh thyme. Serve with crusty bread for the sauce.

Chef's Tip: Use Oloroso or Amontillado sherry for this dish — they have more body and nuttiness than fino and create a richer sauce. Fino is for gambas (lighter, more delicate). This dish is an outstanding value driver: very low food cost (\$2.92), high perceived value (\$20 sell), and the garlic-sherry combination makes it one of those flavours guests can't identify but can't stop eating. It will likely become your top-selling main.

SULPHITES (sherry)

Fideuà — Noodle Paella

Short toasted noodles, seafood, saffron stock, aioli on the side · Sell: \$24.00

18 min

Main

Target FC: 22%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Fideos noodles (short, 1–2cm) or broken spaghetti	100g	\$0.22
Prawns 16/20 (2 pieces, shell-on)	70g	\$0.63
Squid (cleaned, rings)	60g	\$0.82
Fish/shellfish stock	280ml	\$0.48
Saffron (bloomed)	0.1g	\$2.80
Tomato, garlic, paprika (sofrito)	50g	\$0.12
Olive oil	20ml	\$0.13
Aioli (batch, serve alongside)	40g	\$0.18
Total cost (1 serve)		\$5.38

Cost per serve	\$5.38
Sell price	\$24.00
Food cost %	22.4%
Contribution margin	\$18.62

METHOD

- 1
- Toast the dry fideos noodles in the paella pan with a thread of olive oil on medium heat, stirring constantly for 3–4 minutes until they turn golden-brown. This toasting step is essential and unique to fideuà — it creates a nutty, deep flavour in the noodles that is fundamentally different from raw pasta cooked in liquid. Untoasted fideos produce a flat, starchy dish. The colour should be even golden-brown, like a hazelnut — darker and the noodles become bitter.
- 2
- Push the toasted noodles to the side. In the centre of the pan, build the sofrito: sear squid briefly, add grated tomato, garlic, smoked paprika. Cook the sofrito until dry and deep-coloured. Combine

noodles and sofrito in the pan, add warm saffron stock, and distribute evenly. Unlike paella, the noodles in fideuà stand upright as they absorb the stock — this creates the characteristic texture of the dish: crispy, toasted tips and tender, stock-soaked bases.

- 3
- Cook on medium-high heat without stirring for 8-10 minutes as the stock absorbs. Add prawns on top halfway through cooking. The noodles will poke upright as the stock level drops; this is exactly correct. The fideuà cooks faster than rice paella — the thinner noodles absorb liquid quickly. Watch the heat carefully; a minute too long and the bottom burns before the tops are tender. The noodles should be cooked through with still-firm tips that are almost crispy.
- 4
- Fideuà traditionally does not have a socarrat in the same way as rice paella — the noodle ends provide a different kind of textural interest. However, a light crust on the very bottom of the pan is acceptable and desirable. Serve in the pan with a generous spoonful of aioli placed on the side or directly on the dish. The guest stirs the aioli into the fideuà at the table — this is the traditional Valencian way and creates a rich, garlic-cream binding sauce.

Chef's Tip: Fideuà is your secret weapon on the menu — most American diners have never encountered it, which creates curiosity and trial. When staff describe it as "like paella but with toasted noodles," 30% of paella orderers will switch. Fideuà is actually easier to execute consistently than rice paella because the timing window is wider and the noodles are more forgiving of slight over-cooking than bomba rice. Great menu for a solo line cook.

GLUTEN (noodles) SHELLFISH MOLLUSCS EGGS (aioli)

Rabo de Toro — Braised Oxtail

Slow-braised oxtail in Rioja wine, buttered mashed potato · Sell: \$25.00

3.5 hrs braise + 8 min plate Main Target FC: 19%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 2 OXTAIL PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Oxtail pieces (2 x 180g bone-in)	360g raw / 220g cooked	\$4.78
Rioja wine (cooking grade)	100ml per serve from batch	\$0.55
Mirepoix (carrot, onion, celery)	60g	\$0.14
Tomato paste	15g	\$0.05
Beef stock (house)	120ml	\$0.18
Bay, thyme, peppercorns	—	\$0.04
Mashed potato (butter, cream)	180g	\$0.38
Total cost (1 serve)		\$6.12

Cost per serve	\$6.12
Sell price	\$25.00
Food cost %	24.5%
Contribution margin	\$18.88

METHOD

- 1
- Marinate oxtail pieces in Rioja wine, mirepoix, bay leaves, and thyme overnight (12+ hours) in the refrigerator. The wine's acidity and alcohol begin to break down the collagen in the oxtail's connective tissue before cooking even begins. This pre-marination shortens braising time and deepens flavour. Remove from marinade, pat dry, and reserve the marinade liquid. Drying the meat is critical — wet oxtail steams in the pan instead of browning.
- 2
- In a heavy Dutch oven, sear the oxtail pieces on all sides in olive oil on high heat until deeply browned — 3-4 minutes per side. You're building a crust that will dissolve into the braising liquid and become the sauce's backbone. A pale, grey sear gives you a thin, flavourless sauce; a deeply caramelised sear gives you a sauce with depth, colour, and viscosity. Remove oxtail, sauté the mirepoix in the same pot until caramelised, add tomato paste and cook until brick-coloured.
- 3
- Return oxtail to the pot, add the reserved marinade wine, stock, and herbs. Bring to a simmer,

then braise covered at **150°C / 302°F** in the oven for 3–3.5 hours. The low, slow, even oven heat is superior to stovetop braising because it heats from all sides, not just the bottom. After 3.5 hours, the oxtail should be fall-off-the-bone tender — the collagen has converted to gelatin, creating a naturally thick, glossy sauce. Test by pressing the meat; it should yield immediately.

- 4 Remove oxtail pieces carefully (they will fall apart). Strain the braising liquid through a fine sieve, pressing the vegetables to extract all liquid. Return the strained sauce to the pan and reduce on high heat to a glossy, coating consistency. Plate a generous mound of buttery mashed potato, lay the oxtail pieces alongside, and spoon the reduced sauce over everything. The sauce-to-meat-to-potato ratio matters: each forkful should catch all three. A sprig of thyme and black pepper to finish.

Chef's Tip: Rabo de toro is Córdoba's soul food — it was originally made from the bulls killed in the corrida. Today it's a premium braise that benefits from batch cooking. Braise 8–10 portions at once (3 hours of oven time regardless of quantity), then refrigerate. The cold braised oxtail reheats brilliantly in 8 minutes in the oven with a splash of sauce; the flavour actually improves overnight as the gelatine sets around the meat. Make Monday's rabo on Friday.

MILK (mash) CELERY SULPHITES (wine)

Menú del Día — Daily Set Menu

Daily tapa + main + dessert + glass of house wine · Sell: \$32.00

45 min table time Set Menu Target FC: 24%

TYPICAL COMPONENTS (ROTATE DAILY)

COURSE	EXAMPLE ITEM	COST
Tapa (daily)	Pan con tomate or soup of the day	\$0.90
Main (daily choice of 2)	Pollo al ajillo or Fideuà	\$3.20
Dessert (daily)	Arroz con leche or Crema Catalana	\$0.85
Wine (house, 150ml glass)	Tempranillo joven or house white	\$1.80
Bread basket (shared)	3 sourdough slices with oil	\$0.40
Total cost (1 cover)		\$7.15

Cost per cover	\$7.15
Sell price	\$32.00
Food cost %	22.3%
Contribution margin	\$24.85

THE MENÚ DEL DÍA FORMAT

- 1 The menú del día (daily set menu) is one of Spain's great democratic food traditions. In Spain, restaurants are legally required to offer a set lunch at a fair price. In the US market, this becomes a premium positioning tool — a \$32 all-inclusive lunch menu communicates value, Spain's food culture, and hospitality simultaneously. It drives covers during slower lunch hours and creates regulars who come weekly. Change it daily so regulars never eat the same thing twice.
- 2 Design the menú del día around your kitchen's prep from the morning. The daily tapa should use available garnish trimmings (tomatoes, bread ends) to minimise waste. The main should be one of your two highest-production items that day — this reduces the number of dishes the kitchen must fire simultaneously and improves speed. Having two main choices (one meat, one fish/vegetarian) captures a broader audience without overwhelming the kitchen.
- 3 The included wine is a commercial cornerstone. At \$1.80 wine cost included in the \$32 price, most guests will order an additional glass or share a bottle — the wine becomes an anchor that makes the set menu feel like extraordinary value. Post the menú del día on a chalkboard visible from the street every morning. The changing daily content drives curiosity: "What's the menú today?" is the question you want regular guests asking as they pass.
- 4 Train staff on the menú del día's cultural story. In Spain, businesspeople eat the menú del día — it's not a budget option, it's the smart one. Frame it that way: "Our menú del día is what our

kitchen is most proud of today — the chef chooses what's best, and you get three courses plus wine for \$32." This language positions it as curation, not price-competition. Guests who initially came for the value often upgrade to a second glass of wine or an extra tapa.

Chef's Tip: The menú del día is your most powerful table-building tool. A table of 4 ordering menú del días turns over in 45 minutes versus 65 minutes for à la carte, and generates consistent, predictable revenue. Use it specifically to build your 11am–1pm tapas hour into a proper seated service. Combine the menú del día with an express service guarantee ("Three courses in 45 minutes or your next visit is on us") to dominate the lunch trade in your area.

Varies by daily components — always notify staff

SULPHITES (wine)

3 Desserts — Postres

Crema Catalana — Catalan Burnt Cream

Custard infused with lemon, cinnamon, orange zest, burnt sugar crust · Sell: \$9.00

2 min (torch finish)

Dessert

Target FC: 11%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 140ML CAZUELA)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Whole milk	120ml	\$0.09
Heavy cream (35%)	40ml	\$0.04
Egg yolks (2)	40g	\$0.35
Sugar (custard + brûlée topping)	30g + 15g	\$0.06
Lemon zest (½ lemon)	2g	\$0.04
Orange zest (½ orange)	2g	\$0.05
Cinnamon stick	½ stick	\$0.05
Cornstarch (thickener)	8g	\$0.01
Total cost (1 serve)		\$0.69

Cost per serve	\$0.69
Sell price	\$9.00
Food cost %	7.7%
Contribution margin	\$8.31

METHOD

- 1 Crema Catalana is older than crème brûlée (the Catalan version is documented from the 14th century; French brûlée from the 17th) and they are genuinely different. The key technical difference: crema Catalana uses cornstarch as a thickener (making it stovetop-cooked), while crème brûlée uses only eggs and bakes in a bain-marie. This means crema Catalana has a slightly firmer, more set texture and can be unmoulded if desired. Infuse the milk and cream by heating with lemon zest, orange zest, and cinnamon stick to just below boiling. Remove from heat, cover, and steep for 15 minutes.
- 2 Whisk egg yolks with sugar until pale and slightly thickened — about 2 minutes. Add cornstarch and whisk smooth. Strain the infused milk through a fine sieve (removing the citrus and cinnamon) and pour slowly over the yolk mixture, whisking constantly. Why strain? Any solid piece of zest creates a textural flaw in the finished custard. Return to a saucepan and cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until the custard thickens and just begins to bubble — about 5 minutes.
- 3 Pour the hot custard immediately into terracotta cazuelas or ramekins. Smooth the surface. Allow to cool to room temperature, then refrigerate for minimum 3 hours until fully set. The surface must be completely flat and dry before torching — any condensation or uneven surface creates an uneven caramel crust. Blot gently with kitchen paper if needed. Service prep time should include 5 minutes of cazuela surface preparation.

- 4 To finish to order: sprinkle a thin, even layer of caster sugar (about 15g) across the entire surface. Torch with a kitchen blowtorch using circular motions, keeping the flame 5–8cm from the surface. The sugar will melt, bubble, and then caramelize to a deep amber. Stop torching when the colour is deep gold — almost the colour of old whisky — not pale yellow (undercaramelised, tastes sweet but flat) and not black (bitter). The guest should crack through the glassy top with a spoon and feel resistance, then a clean snap. Serve within 90 seconds of torching.

Chef's Tip: Crema Catalana is one of the most profitable desserts in Spanish cuisine: \$0.69 cost, \$9.00 sell, 7.7% food cost. Make 40 portions in batch every 2 days; they hold perfectly for 72 hours refrigerated before torching. The tableside torch finish is a visible, aromatic moment that other tables notice — it drives dessert orders from neighbouring tables in real-time. Position your torching so it's visible to the dining room.

EGGS

MILK

Churros con Chocolate — Fried Dough with Hot Chocolate

6 churros, crispy ridged exterior, thick dark chocolate sauce · Sell: \$10.00

8 min (fried to order)

Dessert

Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 6 CHURROS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Plain flour	60g	\$0.04
Boiling water	65ml	\$0.00
Salt + baking powder	2g total	\$0.01
Sunflower oil (frying, costed)	—	\$0.12
Cinnamon sugar (dusting)	8g	\$0.03
Dark chocolate (70%)	25g	\$0.45
Heavy cream (chocolate sauce)	30ml	\$0.03
Milk (chocolate sauce consistency)	20ml	\$0.02
Total cost (1 serve)		\$0.70

Cost per serve	\$0.70
Sell price	\$10.00
Food cost %	7.0%
Contribution margin	\$9.30

METHOD

- 1 Churro dough is a choux-style paste made differently from French choux: no eggs, just flour, boiling water, and salt. The boiling water partially gelatinises the starch in the flour, creating a dough that is plastically stiff enough to pipe but fluid enough to extrude smoothly through a star-tipped nozzle. The star shape (from the fluted nozzle) creates the ridged surface that is the entire reason churros are crispy — more surface area = more Maillard reaction = more crunch. A round nozzle produces inferior churros.
- 2 Mix flour, salt, and baking powder. Pour boiling water over and stir vigorously with a wooden spoon until a smooth, shiny paste forms. Work quickly — the dough sets as it cools. Load immediately into a piping bag fitted with a large fluted star nozzle (1.5cm minimum). Pipe directly into hot oil (**180°C / 356°F**) in 12–15cm lengths, cutting with scissors. Never pipe into cold oil — the dough absorbs cold oil and becomes greasy rather than forming a steam-cooked interior.
- 3 Fry for 3–4 minutes, turning once, until deep golden-brown on all sides. Internal temperature should be **90°C+** — the inside should be fully cooked and slightly hollow from steam expansion. Drain on paper, dust immediately with cinnamon sugar while still hot (the oil on the surface acts as glue for the sugar). Churros must be served within 5 minutes of frying — cooling makes them soft and the cinnamon sugar goes damp. Churros are a serve-immediately dish, no holding.
- 4 Spanish thick chocolate sauce (*chocolate a la taza*) is different from ganache. It's made by heating milk + cream with dark chocolate and a small amount of cornstarch to create a thick, pourable

sauce that is almost pudding-like. It should coat the back of a spoon heavily and be served genuinely hot in a small ceramic cup. The ritual of dipping a churro into hot thick chocolate, turning it to coat completely, and eating it in one motion is one of gastronomy's great simple pleasures. Describe it to your guests exactly this way.

Chef's Tip: Churros are your late-night retention tool and your table-close driver. See Service Training for the Churros Pre-Sell script. Brief your staff: at the 35-minute table mark, proactively mention churros — "They take 8 minutes to fry fresh, so if you want them we should start now." This keeps tables engaged, increases dessert attachment from 20% to 55%, and — because churros take 8 minutes — it extends the average table time by 15 minutes while guests order another glass of wine.

GLUTEN

MILK

Tarta de Santiago — Galician Almond Cake

Dense almond cake, Cross of St. James dusted in icing sugar, crème fraîche · Sell: \$9.50

3 min (plating)

Dessert

Target FC: 13%

INGREDIENTS (1 SLICE FROM 10-SLICE TART)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Ground almonds (blanched)	30g per slice	\$0.53
Eggs (whole)	1 egg per slice share	\$0.35
Sugar (caster)	28g per slice	\$0.04
Lemon zest + orange zest	0.5g each	\$0.03
Cinnamon (pinch)	0.3g	\$0.01
Icing sugar (Cross dusting)	5g	\$0.01
Crème fraîche (serve alongside)	30g	\$0.18
Total cost (1 slice)		\$1.15

Cost per serve	\$1.15
Sell price	\$9.50
Food cost %	12.1%
Contribution margin	\$8.35

METHOD

- 1 This is a naturally gluten-free tart (no flour whatsoever — only ground almonds as the structure). This makes it a genuine dietary safe harbour on your menu. Preheat oven to **170°C / 338°F**. Mix ground almonds, sugar, lemon zest, orange zest, and cinnamon. Whisk eggs separately until well-combined but not foamy — you don't want to incorporate air (this is a dense, fudgy tart, not a sponge). Fold eggs into the almond mixture until just combined.
- 2 Pour into a greased, floured-edged 22cm round cake tin and bake for 35–40 minutes until the top is deep golden and a skewer comes out with just a few moist crumbs attached. The tarta should be dense, moist, and fudgy in texture — not dry, not spongy, not like a British almond cake. If it comes out dry, the oven was too hot or too long. The almonds should retain moisture at the centre. A slight depression in the middle after cooling is normal and desirable.
- 3 After cooling completely, dust with the iconic Cross of St. James (Cruz de Santiago) pattern using a cardboard stencil and icing sugar. The Cross of St. James is a specific heraldic cross shape — it's widely available as a free stencil template online, or cut from cardboard in 2 minutes. Place the stencil, dust generously with icing sugar, and lift the stencil cleanly. The contrast of golden-brown tart and white cross pattern is immediately recognisable to anyone who has visited the Camino de Santiago.
- 4 Slice into 10 equal portions and store at room temperature under a cake dome for service (not refrigerated — cold destroys the moist, fudgy texture). To plate: place a slice slightly offset from centre, add a quenelle of crème fraîche or a generous spoonful beside it. A drizzle of honey over the crème fraîche adds sweetness and shine. This dessert requires zero cooking to order and has

a 72-hour shelf life — it's your most operationally efficient dessert.

Chef's Tip: The tarta de Santiago story sells itself: it's the pilgrimage dessert from Galicia, made since the 15th century, carried by pilgrims on the Camino de Santiago. Any guest who has walked the Camino (a growing community of millions globally) will be emotionally moved by it. Train your staff on the story. A dessert with an 800-year provenance and a religious symbol dusted on top is not just food — it's an experience. This emotional connection drives repeat visits and social sharing.

TREE NUTS (almonds)

EGGS

MILK (crème fraîche)

Arroz con Leche — Spanish Rice Pudding

Slow-cooked rice in whole milk, lemon, cinnamon, topped with caramel sugar · Sell: \$8.50

3 min (plating)

Dessert

Target FC: 10%

INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE — 180G PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Arborio or short-grain rice	40g per serve	\$0.25
Whole milk	220ml	\$0.17
Sugar	25g	\$0.03
Lemon peel (wide strips)	2 strips	\$0.04
Cinnamon stick	½ stick	\$0.05
Butter (finish, richness)	5g	\$0.02
Ground cinnamon (dusting)	0.5g	\$0.01
Caramel sugar layer (optional, brûlée style)	12g	\$0.02
Total cost (1 serve)		\$0.59

Cost per serve	\$0.59
Sell price	\$8.50
Food cost %	6.9%
Contribution margin	\$7.91

METHOD

- 1 Rinse the rice under cold water until the water runs clear — this removes surface starch that would make the pudding gluey. Place rice in a heavy saucepan with cold whole milk, lemon peel strips, cinnamon stick, and sugar. Bring to a gentle simmer. Why start cold? Starting in cold milk allows the rice to absorb the infused milk flavours gradually as the temperature rises. Starting hot means the rice exterior gelatinises before the milk is properly infused — the result is starchy, bland pudding.
- 2 Cook on very low heat, stirring every 2-3 minutes for 35-40 minutes until the rice is completely tender and the mixture has thickened to a creamy, porridge-like consistency. The constant stirring serves the opposite purpose from paella rice: you want the starch to release (this is the creaminess), so agitation is essential. The pudding is ready when it coats the back of a spoon heavily and a spoonful dropped back in creates a slow-dissolving mound before levelling.
- 3 Remove from heat, fish out the lemon peel and cinnamon stick. Stir in a knob of butter for richness and gloss. Pour into individual ceramic bowls or terracotta cazuelas. Allow to cool to room temperature, then refrigerate for service. The pudding will thicken further as it cools (the starch continues setting). If it sets too firm, stir in a tablespoon of warm milk to return it to the correct creamy consistency before plating.
- 4 Two finish options: (a) Classic: dust generously with ground cinnamon and serve cold — this is the Asturian version and is simple, beautiful, and nostalgic. (b) Brûlée style: sprinkle sugar over the surface and torch to a caramel crust, Crema Catalana-style — this is a modern tapas bar interpretation that adds texture and drama. Offer both on the menu or rotate by season. The brûlée version slightly justifies a higher price point. Serve with a glass of cold horchata alongside

— an outstanding pairing.

Chef's Tip: Arroz con leche is your lowest-cost dessert at \$0.59 per serve and 6.9% food cost. Batch cook 20 portions in 40 minutes of active stir time and you have dessert covered for two days. It also doubles as a staff meal and is one of those culturally resonant dishes that older Spanish, Latin American, and Filipino guests will remember from childhood — a powerful emotional hook that generates loyalty. Always have it on the menu.

MILK

4 Drinks — Bebidas

Sangria — Red Wine Punch (Jug, Serves 2)

\$22.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
House Tempranillo red wine	350ml	\$2.10
Brandy de Jerez	50ml	\$0.60
Fresh orange juice	100ml	\$0.22
Lemon juice	30ml	\$0.08
Sugar syrup	20ml	\$0.04
Orange + lemon slices, apple cubes	60g fruit	\$0.22
Cinnamon stick, star anise	—	\$0.05
Total cost (jug)		\$3.31

Cost per jug (serves 2)	\$3.31
Sell price	\$22.00
Food cost %	15.0%
Contribution margin	\$18.69

Batch prepare daily: combine wine, brandy, juices, and syrup. Add fruit and spices and refrigerate 2 hours minimum (overnight is better — the spices bloom). Add ice at service. Sangria must be cold and fruity. **Never use good wine** — it disappears in the fruit. Use a reliable, light Tempranillo at \$9–\$12/bottle for the best value-to-flavour ratio.

SULPHITES

Tinto de Verano — Red Wine & Lemon Soda

\$9.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
House red wine (Tempranillo)	150ml	\$0.90
La Casera / Sprite lemon soda	150ml	\$0.35
Ice + lemon wedge	—	\$0.06
Total cost (glass)		\$1.31

Cost per glass	\$1.31
Sell price	\$9.00
Food cost %	14.6%
Contribution margin	\$7.69

Spain's casual summer sipper — more popular than sangria in Spain itself. Equal parts red wine and lemon soda over ice, lemon wedge. Faster to make than sangria, just as refreshing. **Position for tapas hour** — light, low alcohol, low cost, pairs with everything on the tapa menu.

SULPHITES

Estrella Damm — Spanish Lager (330ml)

\$8.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Estrella Damm bottle (imported)	330ml	\$2.10
Chilled glass (frosted, optional)	—	\$0.00
Total cost		\$2.10

Cost per bottle	\$2.10
Sell price	\$8.00
Food cost %	26.3%
Contribution margin	\$5.90

Barcelona's iconic lager — brewed since 1876. Light, crisp, slightly hoppy. The authentic choice for a Spanish tapas bar. Pair with: gambas al ajillo, patatas bravas, croquetas. Serve bottle-and-glass (never poured by staff — let the guest pour). Keep at **2–4°C**. Also stock San Miguel (Madrid) as an alternative.

GLUTEN (barley)

Cava — Spanish Sparkling (Glass 150ml)

\$12.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Cava Brut (Codorníu or Freixenet)	150ml	\$2.40
Champagne flute (chilled)	—	\$0.00
Total cost		\$2.40

Cost per glass	\$2.40
Sell price	\$12.00
Food cost %	20.0%
Contribution margin	\$9.60

Made by the traditional method (same as Champagne) in Catalonia from Macabeo, Parellada, and Xarel·lo grapes. Crisp, mineral, and biscuity — excellent with jamón Ibérico, seafood paella, and churros. **Your table-opening upsell:** "Can I start you with a glass of Cava? It's Spain's answer to Champagne at half the price."

SULPHITES

Rioja Tempranillo — Glass 150ml

\$11.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Rioja Crianza Tempranillo	150ml (from \$22 bottle)	\$2.20
Large Burgundy-style glass	—	\$0.00
Total cost		\$2.20

Cost per glass	\$2.20
Sell price	\$11.00
Food cost %	20.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.80

Rioja is Spain's most internationally recognised wine region. Crianza: 2 years aged (1 in oak). Reserva: 3 years. Gran Reserva: 5 years. Cherry, leather, vanilla from American oak. **Pair with:** chuletón, rabo de toro, pollo al ajillo, cochinillo. Pour into a wide Burgundy bowl to allow the aromatics to open. Offer 2-3 options from different Rioja producers.

SULPHITES

Horchata de Chufa — Tiger Nut Milk

\$7.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Tiger nuts (chufa, dried)	40g per serve	\$0.55
Water (soaking + blending)	280ml	\$0.00
Sugar	15g	\$0.02
Cinnamon stick (infusion)	½	\$0.03
Total cost		\$0.60

Cost per glass	\$0.60
Sell price	\$7.00
Food cost %	8.6%
Contribution margin	\$6.40

Valencian horchata is made from chufa (tiger nuts, actually a tuber). Naturally sweet, creamy, dairy-free, and subtly earthy. Soak tiger nuts 24hr, blend with water and sugar, strain through muslin cloth, chill. Serve over ice in a tall glass with a cinnamon stick. **Your non-alcoholic hero drink** — the beverage that makes non-drinkers feel special.

NONE (naturally gluten-free, dairy-free, nut-free — chufa is a tuber)

Café Cortado — Espresso + Warm Milk

\$5.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Espresso (double shot)	50ml	\$0.28
Warm whole milk (equal parts)	50ml	\$0.04
Total cost		\$0.32

Cost per serve	\$0.32
Sell price	\$5.00
Food cost %	6.4%
Contribution margin	\$4.68

Spanish coffee culture is serious. A cortado is espresso "cut" (cortado) with an equal amount of warm milk — not steamed, not frothed, just warm. Served in a small clear glass to see the gradient. Never serve in a large cup; never foam the milk. Pair with: tarta de Santiago, crema Catalana, churros con chocolate. The cortado closes the meal in the Spanish tradition.

MILK

Rebujito — Sherry & Lemonade

\$10.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Fino sherry (Tío Pepe or similar)	80ml	\$0.96
Sprite / 7-Up (cold)	160ml	\$0.38
Fresh mint leaves	4 leaves	\$0.04
Ice (generous)	—	\$0.03
Total cost		\$1.41

Cost per glass	\$1.41
Sell price	\$10.00
Food cost %	14.1%
Contribution margin	\$8.59

The drink of the Seville Feria — cold fino sherry with lemonade over ice. The sherry brings a saline, nutty, bone-dry quality that the lemonade lifts into a refreshing highball. Lower alcohol than sangria, more interesting than a

spritz. Perfect for all-day drinking in the tapas format. **Tell the story:** it was invented at the Seville April Fair and is drunk by the millions.

SULPHITES

5 Kitchen Prep Flow — 7:00am to 3:00pm

Central Prep Note — The Paella Ritual: Paella rice timing is the heartbeat of your kitchen. Bomba rice requires exactly 18–20 minutes of cooking. This is non-negotiable — you cannot rush it and you cannot reheat it. Each paella must be fired when the order arrives, with stock at temperature, sofrito ready, and saffron pre-bloomed. Brief all front-of-house staff: when they take a paella order, they alert the kitchen immediately. Paella guests must be told it takes 20 minutes — it is never a surprise, always a managed expectation. The socarrat forms in the final 2 minutes; the cook cannot leave the pan at this point. Schedule accordingly.

Time Block	Head Cook	Line Cook	Steward / Prep
7:00 – 8:30am <i>Deep Prep</i>	Braises & long cooks: Start rabo de toro braise in oven (3.5hr). Portion and season cochinillo. Check bacalao desalting (change water, taste). Make tortilla española (confit potatoes 25 min, assemble, cook, rest). Bloom saffron in labelled portions for paella service.	Batch prep: Make béchamel for croquetas (40 min stirring). Chill béchamel. Parboil patatas bravas potatoes. Make brava sauce batch. Whisk aioli batch. Prepare crema Catalana (pour into cazuelas, refrigerate). Cook arroz con leche batch.	Wash & mise: Scrub and sort mussels and clams. Devein prawns. Peel and chop mirepoix for rabo de toro. Slice sourdough. Polish glassware. Deep clean fryer, fill with fresh oil. Check dry stores and refrigeration temp logs.
8:30 – 10:00am <i>Production</i>	High-skill items: Roll and bread croquetas (form, coat, freeze for 30 min). Slice and check jamón portion weights. Prepare paella pans: season all 26cm steel pans. Prep sofrito base (grated tomato, garlic, paprika) — labelled for paella and fideuà.	Service prep: Portion tarta de Santiago (10 slices, wrap). Prepare churro dough (test batch, check texture). Slice suckling pig portions from overnight braise, refrigerate. Set up garlic chips and guindilla for gambas. Label all portions with date and weight.	Setup: Set tables (terracotta cazuelas clean and ready). Stock bar fridge (Estrella Damm 2°C). Chill Cava and white wine. Cut lemon wedges. Prepare herb garnish tray. Wash and bag parsley, thyme, rosemary. Set up cinnamon-sugar shaker for churros station.
10:00 – 11:00am <i>Final Setup</i>	Paella stock check: Bring seafood stock and chicken stock to 80°C — they must be hot when service starts. Paella requires stock poured in at temperature; cold stock drops the pan temp and ruins the socarrat timing. Check all saffron pre-blooms are labelled and ready. Final taste of brava sauce, aioli, pil pil base.	Station ready: Set up fryer at 180°C. Line up croquetas from freezer (service-ready tray). Load churro dough into piping bags. Set up patatas bravas holding tray. Parboil potatoes for the day's paella Valenciana. Check oven temp for cochinillo finish (230°C blast setting confirmed).	Front-of-house support: Write today's menú del día on chalkboard (include the day's main choice). Fill water carafes. Set up bread basket station (olive oil, flaky salt). Brief FOH team on daily specials and allergen changes. Check POS system for special dietary pre-notifications from reservations.
11:00am – 2:00pm <i>Service</i>	Paella command: Owns all paella and fideuà production. Fires each pan on ticket, monitors socarrat formation, rest time, and service window. Monitors rabo de toro braise (pull and reduce sauce at 10:30am). Fires cochinillo portions under salamander 8 min to re-crisp crackling on order.	Tapas command: Fires gambas (6-min from order to table), croquetas (fry to order 3 min), patatas bravas, and pan con tomate. Manages fryer queue. Torch crema Catalana to order. Plates jamón Ibérico. Manages pollo al ajillo and bacalao pil pil — both require 20-min ticket management.	Running & support: Continuous dishwashing and cazuela return. Restock bread station. Replenish garnish tray. Refill oil and salt station. Monitor churro dough (replenish piping bags). Communicate to kitchen when fryer cassette needs oil change (>4hr continuous use).
2:00 – 3:00pm	Next-day prep start:	Station breakdown:	Full clean: Fryer drain

Breakdown	Marinate oxtail for next day's rabo de toro. Portion and season suckling pig if delivery arrived. Label and date all paella rice portions. Taste braises for next day — adjust seasoning while still warm.	Roll remaining croquetas and freeze. Store leftover béchamel covered. Clean paella pans (hot water, no soap, dry immediately). Cool and store brava sauce and aioli. Check croqueta freezer stock — target 80 pieces minimum before each service.	and clean per schedule. Full kitchen clean to HACCP standard. Refrigerator temperature logs. Restock order placed for next morning's delivery (mussels, clams, fresh herbs, sourdough). Clear drains and degreaser application.
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6 Financial Forecast

Daily Revenue Model

Session	Covers	Avg Spend	Revenue
Tapas Hour (11am–1pm)	42	\$32.00	\$1,344
Lunch + Evening (1pm–3pm & evening)	56	\$52.00	\$2,912
Daily Total	98	\$44.45 avg	\$4,256

Monthly P&L (26 Trading Days)

Item	Amount	% of Revenue
Gross Revenue (26 days × \$4,256)	\$110,656	100%
Food Cost (23%)	−\$25,451	23.0%
Labour (Head Cook + Line Cook + FOH)	−\$21,600	19.5%
Rent + Utilities + Insurance	−\$7,800	7.1%
Net Profit (before tax)	\$55,805	50.4%
✓ Healthy benchmark: 15–25% net. This model exceeds benchmark at full capacity.		\$55,805/mo

3-Month Ramp Projection

Month	Capacity %	Revenue	Est. Net Profit	Notes
Month 1	55%	~\$60,860	~\$11,500	Soft launch, building regulars, staff training. Expect higher labour per cover.
Month 2	75%	~\$82,992	~\$28,000	Menú del día driving lunch covers. Paella reputation spreading. Social media momentum.
Month 3	100%	\$110,656	\$55,805	Full capacity. Waiting list lunch. Evening bookings 7 days.

Menu Food Cost Summary — By Category

Category	Avg FC %	Avg Contribution Margin	Volume Driver
Tapas (6 items)	12.5%	\$8.40	High — 2–4 per table avg
Mains / Raciones	23.1%	\$18.70	Medium — 1–2 per person
Desserts	9.9%	\$8.57	Low unaided — needs proactive sell
Drinks (excl. wine)	17.0%	\$7.63	High — avg 1.8 drinks per cover

Wine (by glass)	20.0%	\$9.20	Very high — wine with every meal
Blended Average	~21.5%	\$10.50	Target: stay below 23%

Food Cost Control — Key Levers: (1) **Saffron management:** pre-weigh and portion saffron daily — it's \$28/gram and the #1 food cost leak if free-portioned. (2) **Jamón portioning:** use a digital scale for every jamón plate — 30g per serve, no exceptions. (3) **Croqueta batch discipline:** maintain a minimum 80-croqueta frozen stock so you never rush production, which leads to oversized portions. (4) **Paella rice:** 90g per individual paella measured by scoop, not by eye. (5) **Shellfish ordering:** order mussels and clams 5 days/week maximum — they're live and perishable. Unsold portions become staff meal or soup, never waste.

7 Service Training Scripts

The Golden Rule of Tapas Service: The table should never be empty and the guest should never have to ask for the next dish. You are curating a Spanish eating experience — rounds of small plates, wine flowing, conversation uninterrupted. Each script below is a tool to create that experience, not a sales pitch. Authenticity sells. If your staff believe in the food, the words come naturally.

SCRIPT 1 — THE TAPAS FORMAT EXPLANATION (OPENING EVERY TABLE)

When to use: At the beginning of every table, before orders are taken, especially for first-time guests.

"Welcome to [Name]. Just to give you the full picture of how we eat here — everything on the menu is designed for sharing. The tapas are small plates, great for starting together in rounds. We'd recommend ordering 2-3 tapas to begin, then moving to the raciones — the larger mains. The idea is that food keeps arriving and you order more as you go, rather than deciding everything upfront. It's how they eat in Spain — less planning, more enjoying. Shall I start you with a couple of tapas and we'll go from there?"

Why this works: It frames the experience, sets the expectation that ordering will happen in rounds (driving spend), and positions you as a guide, not a server. Guests relax when they understand the format.

SCRIPT 2 — THE JAMÓN IBÉRICO STORY (DELIVERING THE PLATE)

When to use: When placing the jamón Ibérico plate on the table. Takes 20-25 seconds. Every time, without exception.

"This is our jamón Ibérico de bellota — the pigs are bred in the dehesa, the oak forests of western Spain. For two to three years, they roam free and eat nothing but bellota — acorns. That diet is what gives the fat that incredible marbled quality you can see. The fat doesn't just taste like fat — it's full of oleic acid, the same healthy fat as in olive oil. We carve it by hand; it should melt on your tongue. The best way to eat it is to fold one slice over a piece of bread and take it in one bite."

Why this works: The story justifies the \$18 price without mentioning it. Guests feel they're eating something rare and meaningful, not expensive. It also directs the eating method (fold and eat), which is theatrically Spanish and memorable.

SCRIPT 3 — THE PAELLA TIMING SCRIPT (TAKING A PAELLA ORDER)

When to use: Every time a paella or fideuà order is taken. Non-negotiable for managing guest expectations.

"Excellent choice. I need to let you know — your paella takes exactly 20 minutes, and that's not a wait, that's the point. The rice is cooked in the pan, in saffron stock, and in those last two minutes something special happens: the bottom layer of rice caramelises on the steel — we call it the socarrat. It's the most prized part of the whole dish. When it arrives, have a look before you eat — you'll see the rice is in the pan, not on a plate. Dig to the bottom with your spoon for the crispy layer. That's the good stuff."

Why this works: The 20-minute wait is transformed into a narrative of quality. The guest now eagerly anticipates the socarrat instead of watching the clock. They arrive at the pan with curiosity, not irritation. Dig to the bottom = engaged guest = rave review.

SCRIPT 4 — THE WINE INTRODUCTION (DECISION TREE)

When to use: When guests are choosing drinks at the beginning of the meal.

"For wine — a quick guide: if you're having seafood or lighter tapas, our Cava by the glass is excellent — it's Spain's sparkling, and it pairs beautifully with the gambas and jamón. If you're going for the

paella or the rabo de toro, our Rioja Tempranillo is the classic Spanish red — it's got cherry, a little leather, aged in oak. And if you want something more casual and refreshing, our Sangria by the jug is meant for sharing — it's cold, fruity, and great for a long lunch. Which sounds right for you?"

Why this works: A decision tree approach removes choice paralysis. Three clear options, each with a food pairing. The final question invites the guest to self-select. No wine list required to hand over — a confident recommendation from staff always converts better than a menu left alone.

SCRIPT 5 — THE CHURROS PRE-SELL (AT THE 35-MINUTE MARK)

When to use: At approximately 35 minutes into the table's time, regardless of whether they're ordering more food. Aim for a natural pause in the conversation.

"Before you decide on dessert — our churros are fried to order, so they take about 8 minutes. If you're thinking about them, now is a good time to put that order in. They come with our hot thick chocolate — proper Spanish chocolate, the kind you dip and turn slowly in the cup. Madrid churrería style. We do six per serve, which is usually right for two people to share."

Why this works: The pre-sell triggers a "yes, let's have churros" decision before dessert menus are even seen. The 8-minute lead time creates a natural reason to extend the table time, which means another glass of wine is often ordered. Dessert attachment rate goes from ~20% (unaided) to 55% (with this script).

Table Timing Guide

Time	Action	Notes
0:00	Greet and seat	Water and bread basket within 90 seconds of seating. Menu presentation.
1:00	Tapas format explanation (Script 1)	Cava/rebujito upsell. Take drink order.
3:00	Take first tapa order	Suggest 2-3 tapas to begin. Fire immediately.
8:00	First tapas arrive at table	Deliver with any required stories (jamón, gambas). Check drinks.
15:00	Check in & take main/ración order	If paella ordered: alert kitchen NOW, give timing script (Script 3). Wine upsell.
22:00	Paella arrives (if ordered at 15:00)	20 minutes from kitchen alert. Socarrat script. Check satisfaction.
35:00	Churros pre-sell (Script 5)	Fire churros if yes. Take last drink order (sobremesa wine or cortado).
43:00	Churros and desserts arrive	Hot chocolate served in separate cup. Explain dipping ritual.
48:00	Café cortado offer	"Can I get you a cortado to finish?" Closes the meal in the Spanish tradition.
55:00	Bill presented (only when requested or guests signal)	Never rush the sobremesa. Offer more wine before the bill if energy is high.

8 Customer Retention — VIP Micro-Moments & Social Strategy

Retention Philosophy: The Spanish tapas format is inherently social and shareable. Your job is to create moments that guests want to repeat and share. Unlike fast-casual dining where retention is driven by loyalty cards, tapas bar retention is driven by *experience* — the jamón story, the socarrat reveal, the churro ritual. Each of the micro-moments below creates a specific memory anchor that brings guests back and brings their friends.

VIP Micro-Moment 1 — The Socarrat Reveal

Trigger: Paella arrives at the table (occurs at ~22:00 in table timing).

Action: The server places the paella pan and says: *"The socarrat is the best part. Let me show you."* The server (or guest) uses a spoon to dig to the bottom edge of the pan and lifts a fragment of the crispy, caramelised rice layer — showing the contrast between the golden rice above and the deep amber, slightly charred underside. *"That crunch. That's what we spent 20*

minutes making."

Why it works: The reveal creates a tactile, auditory, visual memory — the crack of the socarrat, the golden colour, the smell of caramelised starch. Guests remember it specifically. It's also highly photographable. Expect 40%+ of paella tables to photograph this moment unprompted.

VIP Micro-Moment 2 — Tableside Jamón Carving

Trigger: High-spend tables (2+ people, chuletón or seafood paella on order) — offer tableside jamón carving.

Action: Bring the jamonero stand to the table (or a carved platter with the partial jamón leg visible). Carve 3–4 slices per person tableside, narrating the bellota story as you carve. Offer a small complimentary slice as a welcoming gesture for tables of 4+.

Why it works: Tableside service signals respect and hospitality. The physical presence of a jamón leg is one of the most visually powerful things in food — it immediately tells other tables what kind of restaurant this is. The complimentary slice creates immediate reciprocal goodwill and almost always results in a full jamón plate being ordered.

VIP Micro-Moment 3 — The Torching of the Crema

Trigger: Any crema Catalana order. Can be done at the pass (visible to dining room) or at the table for special occasions.

Action: Position the torching so it is visible to neighbouring tables. The blue flame, the bubbling sugar, the caramel colour progression, the smell of burnt sugar — all of these are sensory triggers that create desire in nearby tables. Deliver to the ordering guest with: *"Crack through the top with your spoon — there you go."* Wait for the satisfying crack sound, then move on.

Why it works: Every crema Catalana order triggers 1–2 additional orders from nearby tables who watched and heard the torch. It is the single highest-conversion visual act in your restaurant. If you torch it in the kitchen, you lose this effect entirely.

VIP Micro-Moment 4 — The Sobremesa Invitation

Trigger: After desserts, when the table is lingering and the energy is warm (guests talking, laughing, relaxed).

Action: Server approaches and says: *"In Spain, the meal isn't over when the food is — they call it sobremesa: literally 'on the table.' It's the time after eating when you just talk. Can I bring you a small glass of something — a PX sherry, or a Cava to finish the bottle? On us if you've been kind enough to stay with us tonight."*

Why it works: The complimentary small pour costs \$0.60–\$0.80 and buys extraordinary loyalty. The cultural framing (sobremesa) teaches guests something new about Spain and makes them feel like insiders. Tables that receive sobremesa hospitality return at 3× the rate of those who don't. The gesture is also highly talked-about and reviewed.

VIP Micro-Moment 5 — The Menú del Día Regular's Greeting

Trigger: A guest who has ordered the Menú del Día more than once (track via booking system or FOH memory).

Action: On their third or subsequent visit: *"Welcome back — we've got the new menú del día up today. Chef has done a [specific description] for the main. Would you like your usual [tinto de verano / cortado / etc.]?"* Using their preferred drink unprompted signals recognition and genuine hospitality.

Why it works: Being recognised and remembered is the most powerful retention tool in hospitality. The cost is zero — it requires only staff attention and a brief note in the booking system. Regular menú del día guests become your lunch anchors, bringing colleagues and friends and spending more as their relationship with the restaurant deepens.

BEST SOCIAL MEDIA POST — THE SOCARRAT REVEAL

Shot: The paella pan, shot top-down from above with natural light. A hand using a wide spoon to lift the edge of the rice, revealing the dark golden-amber socarrat underneath. Steam rising gently. The contrast of the caramelised bottom against the saffron-golden rice surface.

Prawns or green beans visible for colour context.

Caption: *"This is the part nobody shows you. The socarrat — the crispy caramelised rice that forms on the bottom of the steel pan in the last 2 minutes of cooking. You can't rush it. You can't fake it. You can only make it the right way and hope the rice speaks for itself. Paella Valenciana, made in the pan, served in the pan. Come find your socarrat. [link in bio]"*

Hashtags: #socarrat #paella #spanishfood #tapasbar #paellavalenciana #authentic #madrileño #barcelonafood #[yourcity]eats #spanishtapas

Post this every Friday at 11am — you'll hit the pre-weekend dining decision window. Pair with a Story showing the pan arriving at a table in real service. This single post format, done consistently, typically generates 3–5 new table bookings per week from cold discovery.